

Chapter 99-1

When Liang Shi returned home, Su Yao was sitting in the living room. She nodded in greeting.

Su Yao asked her a few questions with concern, and she answered each one.

Then Xu Qingzhu pushed her into the bathroom, telling her to take a shower, while Xu Qingzhu and Su Yao went downstairs to buy breakfast and take a walk.

Liang Shi had just taken off her clothes in the bathroom when someone knocked on the door.

Liang Shi hurriedly put her clothes back on and opened the door to find Sheng Yu, rubbing her sleepy eyes. Her hair had a slight natural curl, and the fine, soft strands were sticking to her face. She closed her eyes and frowned as she brushed the hair away, yawned, and said, "Jiejie, I need to pee-pee."

Liang Shi let her go in while she waited outside. But not even two seconds later, the door suddenly opened and Sheng Yu asked in delighted surprise, "Liang-jiejie! You're back!"

Liang Shi: "....."

So she hadn't noticed her just now?

Liang Shi stroked her fine, soft hair and squatted down to ask, "Did you finish peeing?"

Sheng Yu slapped her forehead. "Oh no!"

Liang Shi held her hand. "Doesn't that hurt? You still have a bandage on your head."

Sheng Yu didn't even have time to answer her and rushed back into the bathroom in a panic.

Liang Shi found it amusing.

Even so, Sheng Yu hurriedly finished using the toilet and quickly came back out.

She had been so drowsy before that she couldn't even open her eyes, but now her eyes were sparkling bright. She hugged Liang Shi and asked, "Liang-jiejie, when did you get back?"

"Just got back." Liang Shi gently smoothed out her messy hair, then took the hair tie from her own wrist and loosely wrapped it around three times to tie up Sheng Yu's hair. Then she pushed her shoulders. "Go back to the room and continue sleeping. I'm going to take a shower."

"Okay." Sheng Yu rubbed her eyes, as if afraid Liang Shi would disappear.

But she couldn't stop Liang Shi from taking a shower, so she could only drag her feet back to the room, looking back every few steps, reluctant to part.

Liang Shi felt warm inside. She went in to shower, while Sheng Yu returned to the room only to find her spot was gone. Ling Dang had already rolled to the middle and was sprawled out with limbs everywhere, pressed up against Rainbow.

Sheng Yu sighed, having formed a basic assessment of Classmate Liang Wenxuan's sleeping abilities. She rubbed her own bottom—she had been kicked several times by Liang Wenxuan last night.

Really!

Whoever sleeps with Liang Wenxuan is out of luck!

She was about to climb onto the bed when she noticed Liang Wenxuan turn over and kick Rainbow right in the back.

Rainbow had been sleeping soundly. After being kicked, she also turned over and half-opened her eyes to look. But then Ling Dang's arm draped over Rainbow, her arms and legs pinning Rainbow down.

Rainbow, still groggy, rolled toward Sheng Yu's side.

Sheng Yu shook her head helplessly and got onto the bed to squeeze in with them.

The bed was big enough to comfortably fit all three of them, but the three of them insisted on squeezing together.

Sheng Yu had been drowsy and almost fell back asleep when Ling Dang's arm landed on her face, smacking her awake.

Sheng Yu opened her mouth and bit Ling Dang's arm.

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Ling Dang woke up.

Immediately after, Ling Dang kicked her feet in anger, which also kicked Rainbow awake.

Rainbow asked Ling Dang, "Why did you kick me?"

Ling Dang asked Sheng Yu, "Why did you bite me?"

Sheng Yu sat up and said huffily, "You two are so heartless! Liang-jiejie is back and you don't even care!"

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And so, three little kids, wearing little tank tops and underwear, ran to the bathroom door without even putting on slippers.

Meanwhile, Liang Shi was in such a good mood that she was singing in the bathroom. "Like a spring breeze blowing past my cheek, like a light rain falling on my shoe tips..."

Sheng Yu pressed her head against the door. "Liang-jiejie is singing."

Ling Dang nodded. "I hear it too. It sounds so nice!"

Rainbow was puzzled. "Did something happy happen?"

Sheng Yu and Ling Dang shook their heads in unison. "Don't know!"

Because their shaking frequency wasn't synchronized, their heads bumped into each other.

Sheng Yu covered her head and was about to scold Ling Dang, but Ling Dang didn't bother to rub her own bumped head first. Instead, she reached out to rub Sheng Yu's forehead and said guiltily, "I'm sorry, does it hurt?"

Sheng Yu pouted, then smiled. "Of course it doesn't hurt! Hehe."

Rainbow watched from the side, feeling quite gratified.

These two had finally stopped fighting.

Chapter 99-2

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After Liang Shi finished her shower, she changed into pajamas. She casually towed her hair dry, leaving it half-damp and uncombed.

Curly hair was more troublesome to manage, so she wasn't in the habit of combing it right after washing. She would wait until it was about seventy percent dry before combing.

But the moment she opened the door, she saw three little kids standing in a neat row at the entrance, all tilting their heads up to look at her with sparkling eyes.

Most crucially—they weren't wearing clothes.

Liang Shi was startled and her expression immediately changed. "What are you all doing? Go back to bed and lie down."

"Auntie." Ling Dang said coquettishly. "You're back! They didn't hit you, did they?"

"No." Liang Shi said while pulling them back to the room. "You're not even wearing clothes. You'll catch a cold."

No sooner had she finished speaking than Rainbow sneezed.

"See?" Liang Shi quickly carried her back to bed and covered her with the blanket. "How long were you standing at the door?"

"Don't know." Ling Dang was the easiest to get information out of. "We've been standing there since you started singing."

Liang Shi: "....."

When had she been singing?

She didn't even know herself.

Anyway, these kids' bodies were all chilly. One touch and you could tell they had been standing there for a long time.

After tucking them all under the blankets, Sheng Yu leaned close to Rainbow and lowered her voice to say, "See, people who don't exercise regularly have weak bodies. We're all fine, but you're the one sneezing!"

Rainbow pursed her lips. "That's not true."

Sheng Yu said, "It is true. Are you going to come play with me after class from now on?"

Rainbow firmly refused. "No."

"Then keep getting sick! Nyeh nyeh~" Before she even finished speaking, her nose twitched and she immediately covered her mouth and sneezed. Even so, Rainbow sitting beside her was caught in the crossfire. But Rainbow calmly wiped her face. "Running around randomly isn't exercise. Your immune system is pretty weak too."

Sheng Yu rubbed her nose, like a proud little peacock. "Hmph! What do you know? My sister said: one sneeze means someone's thinking of you, two means someone's cursing you, three means you have a cold.¹ I only sneezed once, so that means someone is... achoo!"

The proud little peacock hadn't even finished showing off before she sneezed again.

Ling Dang, nestled in Liang Shi's arms, laughed and couldn't help saying, "Sheng Yu, does that mean someone's cursing you now?"

"Yeah." Sheng Yu kicked Rainbow under the blanket. "I said that about Zhou Caihong, so she's definitely cursing me in her heart... achoo!"

.....

Rainbow moved farther away from her. "I didn't curse you. Your immune system is weak. You caught a cold."

Sheng Yu rubbed her nose, the tip all red, and huffed at Rainbow. "You definitely infected me."

Rainbow: "....."

She really wanted to say that colds couldn't spread that fast.

But a few seconds later, Rainbow said very seriously, "You said it yourself—one sneeze means someone's thinking of you, two means cursing, three means a cold. I only sneezed once, so someone's thinking of me. But you sneezed three times, so you have a cold. I don't."

Sheng Yu: "?"

Awoo.

That detestable Rainbow.

Rainbow, having finally won a verbal victory, secretly smiled and raised an eyebrow at Liang Shi.

Liang Shi secretly gave her a thumbs up.

Meanwhile, Ling Dang nestled in Liang Shi's arms and asked her what happened last night. Did those people bully her?

Liang Shi answered patiently, "The police uncles protect good people. Auntie just made a small mistake, and after apologizing, they let me go. How could I have been bullied?"

Ling Dang was still conflicted. She apologized guiltily, her voice muffled. "Auntie, I'm sorry. If it weren't for me, you wouldn't have gone to beat someone up."

"Oh, come on." Liang Shi looked at her already reddening eyes and reached out to pinch her cheek. "Why is our little Ling Dang being so sentimental now? It was just a small thing. Hitting people is wrong, but it also depends on who you're hitting."

Seeing that Ling Dang still couldn't cheer up, Liang Shi asked Sheng Yu, who was still trying to battle Rainbow for three hundred rounds, "Sheng Yu, would you say I looked cool when I hit that person yesterday?"

"Super cool!" Sheng Yu immediately got excited. She gestured while talking. "Last night, jiejie just knocked that ugly auntie right down. When she grabbed her hand, that auntie's hand was like a chicken claw, like this..."

She imitated it perfectly, then scoffed. Seeing Ling Dang still looking aggrieved while nestled in Liang Shi's arms, looking like she was about to cry, she couldn't help poking her forehead. "Liang Wenxuan, you're so annoying."²

Liang Shi: "?"

Where did this random accent come from?

"That person cursed at us." Sheng Yu stood on the bed, looking just like a knight about to go conquer the world—except this knight's hair wasn't cooperating and kept getting in her mouth. She spat it out and threw that strand of hair behind her ear. "To be able to say such horrible things to cute kids like us—doesn't she have children of her own?! If my mom and uncle had heard it yesterday, they would have beaten her to death!"

"But even without mom and uncle, my two jiejies could have beaten her to death!" Sheng Yu said matter-of-factly. "People who curse at children deserve to be hit. But Liang-jiejie hit someone, so being taken away by the police uncles is also deserved. When you do something wrong, there are consequences."

After Sheng Yu finished, she kicked Rainbow. "Applause!"

Rainbow: "....."

Ling Dang listened in a daze, but she didn't understand. "What does 'annoying' mean?"²

Sheng Yu: "It means you're being wishy-washy."

Ling Dang: "....."

Liang Shi was amused by Sheng Yu's quirky antics, holding back her laughter until her stomach hurt.

One second the "Queen Sheng" was giving a passionate speech, and the next she was scooped up by Liang Shi and tossed into the blanket, wrapped up into a ball.

"You really aren't afraid of catching a cold." Liang Shi pinched her cheek. "I'll make you some ginger sugar water to drink later. Don't go running around without clothes on. It's been cold these past few days."

Sheng Yu stuck her tongue out at her, rolled around next to her, and called out to Rainbow who seemed isolated from the world. "Come on, Zhou Caihong, let's roll onto Liang-jiejie together and fill up her arms."

Rainbow was a bit cautious, not used to Sheng Yu's wild way of acting spoiled.

Seeing her like this, Liang Shi immediately waved to her. "Rainbow, come here quickly. I'll hold you, not Sheng Yu."

Sheng Yu scrambled over with flailing limbs. "No way."

Footnotes:

¹ This is a Chinese folk belief about sneezing. The full saying goes: "一想二罵三感冒" (yī xiǎng èr mà sān gǎnmào) - one sneeze means someone is thinking of you, two sneezes means someone is cursing/badmouthing you, and three sneezes means you have a cold.

² "機車" (jīchē): This is Taiwanese slang that literally means "motorcycle" but is used to describe someone who is annoying, troublesome, or being difficult. It's a distinctly Taiwanese expression, which is why Liang Shi was puzzled about where the accent came from.

Chapter 99-3

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On this bed, Liang Shi was thoroughly worn out.

Sheng Yu was a little demon king. Ling Dang had been well-behaved at first, but then she joined in on the chaos. They made such a ruckus that Liang Shi lay exhausted on the bed with three little kids nestled around her.

Liang Shi held them down. "Alright, ceasefire."

Ling Dang nuzzled against her shoulder. "Auntie, then sing for us."

"Yay~!" Sheng Yu also said, "Sing the one you were singing in the bathroom just now. I want to hear it!"

Liang Shi: "....."

She really didn't remember singing!

Rainbow nodded. "It was very nice. The lyrics were good too."

Liang Shi asked, "You still remember them?"

Rainbow recited the lyrics like an emotionless reading machine.

Liang Shi roughly knew which song it was now. It had been sitting in her playlist gathering dust for a long time. There was a period when she had especially liked listening to it.

It also existed in this world. When she was taken away last night, one of the officers had this song as their phone ringtone, which awakened her memory.

She was about to sing when Ling Dang frowned. "That's not how it goes."

Rainbow said matter-of-factly and righteously, "I'm tone-deaf."

"Then recite the lyrics again." Ling Dang said.

Rainbow repeated them. Ling Dang worked hard to memorize the lyrics, then placed her short little fingers on Liang Shi's stomach.

Liang Shi felt her fingers tapping out a rhythm. After four beats, Ling Dang suddenly started singing, "Like a spring breeze blowing past my cheek, like a light rain falling on my shoe tips..."

Her voice was very clear and crisp, carrying a milky childish innocence. It didn't have the technical skill of an adult's singing, but it was full of emotion.

She had imitated about seventy percent of the original.

But she could only remember those two lines. By the third line, she could only hum the melody.

Liang Shi continued singing along with her rhythm. "Like the fallen leaves swirling on an autumn street, like a lamp going out in the endless night..."

Ling Dang gently tapped Liang Shi's stomach through the blanket to keep the beat. Sheng Yu saw this and followed suit.

Only Rainbow was thinking: Those two are so childish.

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When Xu Qingzhu and Su Yao returned, this was the scene they saw.

Liang Shi sat in the middle of the bed, her hair seventy percent dry, pajamas loosely draped on her body, surrounded by three little kids, singing gently.

A gentle person even had a gentle voice. It was like she was singing a slow love song, full of patience.

Su Yao stood beside her and said softly, "A-Shi sings quite nicely too."

Xu Qingzhu nodded. "Not bad."

The two of them didn't interrupt the warm scene in the room and went straight to the kitchen.

In the kitchen, Su Yao asked Xu Qingzhu, "Do you still have a lot of work at the company?"

Xu Qingzhu nodded. "A lot."

After Xu Guangyao had talked with her last time, he had given her authority. She was no longer in the Design Department—she had given the position of Acting Department Head to Sally. She went directly to the President's Office and became the General Manager.

She was currently in a phase of sweeping reforms. To rectify Minghui's current culture, she would inevitably have to change the practice of "appointing people based on personal connections" and find various reasons to lay off those who had gotten into the company through nepotism but had no actual ability.

So work was still very busy. During the day at the company, she was working non-stop without rest. Only on Saturdays and Sundays could she squeeze out a little bit of time.

After a while, she probably wouldn't even have weekends free anymore.

There was a rest room in the President's Office. She would probably be living there for a long time.

So whether or not she moved didn't really matter.

"Then you need to take care of your health." Su Yao reminded her. "I don't understand business matters, but if you need help with anything, just tell me, or tell your uncle. He'll definitely help you."

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

She was stunned for a few seconds, then smiled helplessly. "Okay."

This was also the first time she had heard that when you run into problems, you could go ask your rival for help.

But she had no such plans. She didn't want to compete with Haiwei Jewelry for a share of the market pie.

Doing business wasn't about "what you have, I must not have." Smart people would choose a situation of mutual benefit and win-win.

Su Yao helped her divide the things they had bought onto plates.

Xu Qingzhu took the milk out of the refrigerator and poured it into cups to heat up for the children.

Su Yao hesitated to speak several times. Xu Qingzhu glanced at her repeatedly and took the initiative to ask, "Is there something you want to say?"

"Are you pregnant?" Su Yao asked quietly.

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

She shook her head. "No."

Su Yao lowered her eyes, hesitating again, not knowing whether she should say these things.

Xu Qingzhu hesitated for a moment, then put her arm around Su Yao's shoulder. "Just say whatever you want to say. I'm listening."

Su Yao first said, "Just listen to what I have to say. If you don't like it, just pretend I never said it, and don't take it too much to heart."

Xu Qingzhu was startled, wondering what she was going to say.

After waiting for a while, Su Yao said with concern, "I can see that A-Shi really likes children. When are you two planning to have kids? You're so busy with the company now, and her career should have just started too, right? If you have children, your aunt-in-law and I can help take care of them, but it's still better for children to grow up by their mother's side. Otherwise..."

She paused, thinking of her own situation over the years.

"Anyway, I just want to say that you need to plan for this. If you suddenly get pregnant in the middle of building your career, the child might seem like a bit of an inconvenience." Su Yao said. "And remember to ask A-Shi what she thinks, to see when would be a good time for you two to have children. Two people need to be on the same page about these things, otherwise it can easily sour the relationship."

Xu Qingzhu knew everything she said was right, but worrying about these issues now was premature.

However, she didn't refute Su Yao's words. Instead, she nodded and said she understood, telling her not to worry.

When the kitchen quieted down, Xu Qingzhu could still hear singing coming from next door.

Liang Shi really seemed to like children, and she was especially indulgent with them.

Chapter 99-4

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Originally, Liang Shi had invited Xu Qingzhu to go to an escape room on Saturday. In order to complete the task given by the system, Liang Shi was prepared to go all out.

But plans changed. With a group of little kids in tow, they could only go to the amusement park.

Three adults brought three children. The kids started sprinting the moment they entered, constantly getting lost.

Liang Shi told them to hold hands and not run around randomly, then took them to ride the carousel.

"Queen Sheng" had lofty ambitions and wanted to ride the roller coaster, but was held back by Su Yao.

When adults accompany children to an amusement park, they can only play a supporting role.

Whatever rides the kids wanted to go on, the adults just had to accompany them. There was no need to have their own ideas, because kids nowadays had too many ideas of their own.

Rainbow was the most well-behaved—so well-behaved it was almost heartbreaking.

She didn't do anything on her own or make any requests. Instead, it was Liang Shi who kept encouraging her, asking her what she wanted and what she wanted to do.

But before Rainbow could even speak, "Queen Sheng" waved her little hand. "Zhou Caihong, let's go ride the bumper cars!"

Liang Shi asked her, "Do you want to play?"

Rainbow pressed her lips together. "We can play."

"Queen Sheng" came over directly and dragged her away. "Why aren't you happy even at the amusement park? Isn't it tiring keeping a straight face all day? Zhou Caihong, I don't understand you."

Ling Dang chimed in from the side. "I don't understand either."

Rainbow huffed lightly. "You just need to understand Shen Yiran."

But Ling Dang made a face at her. "Don't think I don't know Shen Yiran likes you!"

Rainbow: "....."

A few seconds later, Rainbow asked very seriously, "At your age, can you really understand what 'liking someone' means?"

Sheng Yu & Ling Dang: "....."

"Liang Wenxuan." Sheng Yu grabbed Ling Dang's hand. "Come on, let's crash into her!"

Rainbow, who had unknowingly made enemies again: "....."

While taking care of them, Xu Qingzhu told Liang Shi everything she had seen at the hospital last night.

Liang Shi was also more inclined to think it was this family of scammers who had happened to run into Guo Xinran, and then Guo Xinran had used inappropriate methods to deal with the problem.

But the possibility that the two were working together couldn't be ruled out.

If they really were working together, then this problem was terrifying to think about.

The two of them discussed for a while and decided they still needed to find Liang Xinhe and Sun Meirou. After all, they were Ling Dang's parents.

If the two of them rashly got involved now, it wouldn't attract any attention and would only get them into trouble.

After the three children finished playing at the amusement park in the morning, Zhou Li came to pick up Rainbow.

Afterward, Xu Qingzhu and Su Yao took Sheng Yu to the hospital for a follow-up check. Although they knew it probably wasn't anything serious, it was better to get an X-ray just to be safe.

Meanwhile, Liang Shi took Ling Dang to find Liang Xinhe.

When Xu Qingzhu arrived, there was no one in Shen Hui's office. Shen Hui was sitting there browsing video files. When she saw Xu Qingzhu coming with Sheng Yu, she glanced behind them.

Xu Qingzhu smiled. "She didn't come."

Shen Hui let out an "oh" and re-dressed Sheng Yu's wound. After examining it carefully, she said it was fine and there was no need for an X-ray.

They followed the doctor's advice.

Xu Qingzhu then asked Shen Hui about the situation regarding Xu Tong. Shen Hui only mentioned Xu Tong's parents and didn't reveal much about the child's condition. What she said was similar to what Dr. Han had said last night.

After Shen Hui finished speaking, she asked, "What's the little girl who pushed someone to you?"

"She's Liang Shi's niece." Xu Qingzhu said. "The little girl says she didn't push anyone. She's been terribly wronged."

"Alright, so she got scammed."¹ Shen Hui said. "Go check the surveillance footage carefully. There might be some clues."

Xu Qingzhu thanked her. Shen Hui shook her head. "It's nothing."

Xu Qingzhu was about to leave, but paused at the door and suddenly asked, "Dr. Shen, can I ask you something personal?"

Shen Hui understood immediately. "Is it about Zhao Xuning?"

Xu Qingzhu nodded. "Yes. If Liang Shi's behavior this morning made you uncomfortable, I can have her apologize another day."

"No need." Shen Hui said. "I didn't take it to heart."

Xu Qingzhu pressed her lips together and sat back down, right across from Shen Hui.

Only when facing her directly did she notice the heavy dark circles under Shen Hui's eyes. She looked extremely tired. "Did you come to work without going home to rest this morning?"

"Mm." Shen Hui pressed on her eyes. "What about it?"

"I'm sorry." Xu Qingzhu said. "We were impulsive last night."

Shen Hui said flatly, "You're not the first ones to cause a scene in my office. I'm used to it."

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

Shen Hui's attitude was very cold, perhaps because she had mentioned Zhao Xuning.

Footnotes:

¹ "Got scammed" (被訛上了, bèi è shàng le): This phrase refers to being falsely accused or extorted, typically when someone pretends to be injured or harmed to demand compensation. It's a common concern in China, particularly with cases of people falsely claiming they were pushed or injured to extort money from innocent bystanders.

Chapter 99-5

Xu Qingzhu didn't know if she could still ask her follow-up questions. After hesitating, she chose not to ask, but instead said softly, "I'm not speaking on Dr. Zhao's behalf. It's just that you surely have your reasons for breaking up, and you have your reasons for not forgiving her."

Xu Qingzhu said, "Liang Shi and I shouldn't have interfered with the relationship between you two, but Liang Shi went to your apartment before."

Shen Hui paused. "Which one?"

"The one in Chenjiang Community." Xu Qingzhu said. "We're living on the 10th floor now, because Dr. Zhao said your birthday is in October."

Shen Hui lowered her eyes, her tone softening with a hint of tenderness. "So you're living there now."

"What about the top floor?" Shen Hui asked.

Xu Qingzhu said, "It's still empty. Liang Shi said there are too many memories of you two there—precious and beautiful—so she kept it for Dr. Zhao."

Shen Hui suddenly chuckled softly. "But no matter how precious and beautiful memories are, they can only ever be memories."

Xu Qingzhu paused for a moment. "Although I don't know what happened between you two, Dr. Zhao really loves you. You should understand her better than we do, right? She's not great with words, and she's quite tsundere.¹ When I first met her, I thought there was no way I could ever become friends with her, but later... I felt like she's really a person of integrity."

The word Liang Shi had once used to describe Zhao Xuning really couldn't be more fitting.

"Being the kind of friend who doesn't need to be too close to her is very comfortable." Xu Qingzhu said. "She's helped us a lot. I have no way to repay her, so I can only come bother you with a few words."

Shen Hui chuckled softly. "A person of integrity?"

Xu Qingzhu nodded. "Her reason for not dating is because she can't forget her ex-girlfriend."

"However..." Xu Qingzhu smiled slightly. "If she did something unforgivable to you, then just move forward. No matter how much she loves you, that's her business. You don't need to be morally blackmailed."

Shen Hui rested her chin on her hand, her eyes half-closed. The atmosphere suddenly fell silent.

After a long while, Shen Hui said slowly, "Back then, what she lost wasn't just me, but also our child."

Shen Hui's eyes reddened. "She didn't do anything wrong, and I didn't do anything wrong either. But we lost our child. So that means she was wrong, and I was wrong too."

Xu Qingzhu hurriedly handed her tissues. Shen Hui's tears fell, glistening teardrops hanging on her long eyelashes.

Shen Hui wiped them away, then said to Xu Qingzhu, "You're right. I understand better than anyone what kind of person Zhao Xuning is."

After a long silence, her nose stung with emotion and she turned her face away. "That's exactly why I can't forgive her even more."

Rather than saying she couldn't forgive her, it would be more accurate to say she couldn't forgive herself.

Zhao Xuning had always kept her distance from other women. She was never ambiguous with anyone. In five years of dating, Shen Hui had almost never seen any flirtatious messages on her phone.

Yet on that particular day, she was tricked into going to a birthday party and drank spiked alcohol.

And Shen Hui just happened to see it.

What about her then?

She knew Zhao Xuning wasn't that kind of person, but she still lost control when she saw that scene.

Someone who had never suffered any grievances—how could she have such a strong heart? She was so angry that she went out into the rain and got knocked down by someone.

She had just found out there was a little life in her belly. She had fantasized about it for so long at home, even coming up with more than a dozen names for Zhao Xuning to choose from. But before Zhao Xuning even knew the little life existed, the child was gone.

In less than twelve hours.

Her hopes and expectations were shattered in less than twelve hours.

She couldn't get past it.

She was wrong, and Zhao Xuning was wrong too.

They were both paying for their own mistakes.

Shen Hui rarely talked about this with others. She rarely even mentioned that she once had a child.

But suddenly bringing it up, she found it wasn't that hard to say after all.

Shen Hui looked at Xu Qingzhu. "Little sister, she's a person of integrity, and she still loves me, but there's no going back for us."

Xu Qingzhu met her gaze, then suddenly raised her hand to wipe away her tears.

Her cool fingernips touched the area under Shen Hui's eyes. Xu Qingzhu said gently, "Jiejie, let me treat you to drinks sometime."

Shen Hui raised an eyebrow. The corners of her mouth slowly curved up into a captivating smile. "Oh?"

"To the present." Xu Qingzhu said. "To freedom."

Not a single mention of Zhao Xuning.

Xu Qingzhu said, "If a relationship is a swamp, then we stride forward. Our lives move in many directions, not just straight down."

Shen Hui: "Oh?"

Xu Qingzhu patted her arm. "What I mean is, there are plenty of people in this world who are better than Dr. Zhao."

Shen Hui: "....."

She switched sides just like that?

Shen Hui was amused by her. "Add me on WeChat."

Xu Qingzhu took out her QR code. "When you have a day off, let me know. I'll treat you to drinks."

Shen Hui nodded. "Sure, but you can't bring that person."

Xu Qingzhu: "?"

Shen Hui said, "Girls' gatherings don't include partners."

"Okay." Xu Qingzhu agreed readily.

Footnotes:

¹ Tsundere (傲娇, àojiāo): A Japanese term that has been adopted into Chinese internet slang. It describes a personality type that is initially cold, aloof, or even hostile on the outside, but gradually shows a warmer, more caring side. The word combines "tsuntsun" (aloof/cold) and "dederere" (lovestruck/affectionate).

Chapter 99-6

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After Xu Qingzhu left the hospital, she sent Liang Shi a message: [Stop meddling in other people's business from now on!]

Liang Shi, who had just arrived at Dongheng with Ling Dang: [Whose business?]

Xu Qingzhu: [Dr. Zhao and Dr. Shen's.]

Liang Shi: [How would I dare anymore? I just couldn't stand watching Zhao Xuning keep her mouth shut when she should speak up.]

And after she helped speak up, she got sold out in return.

She had witnessed the shattering of a plastic friendship.

Liang Shi: [You saw Dr. Shen?]

Xu Qingzhu: [Mm, we even added each other on WeChat.]

Liang Shi: [shivering.jpg Dr. Shen really knows how to steal someone's wall.¹]

Xu Qingzhu: [...Yes, are you scared?]

Liang Shi: [I think Teacher Xu is a firm wall that can't be pried away.]

Xu Qingzhu: [That depends on who's doing the prying. I quite like Shen Hui-jiejie.]

Liang Shi: [!]

Liang Shi sent her a "nooo~" sticker, then took Ling Dang upstairs to Liang Xinhe's office.

Because both Qiu Zimin and Guo Xinran were hospitalized at the same time, Liang Xinhe had stayed at the hospital all night. So had Sun Meirou.

After a sleepless night, they still had to spin around like tops. They changed clothes in the morning and rushed to the company.

Last night, Liang Xinhe and Sun Meirou had been planning to move out of the old residence.

Liang Xinhe had still been somewhat hesitant. After all, when his older brother moved out, it had already made Qiu Zimin furious. If he moved out now too and quit his job on top of that, Qiu Zimin would probably be so angry she'd have to live in the hospital permanently.

When his older brother was still around, he at least had someone to discuss things with. Now his older brother wouldn't even answer his calls.

He had a bellyful of grievances and frustrations with nowhere to pour them out.

But when he saw Ling Dang, her eyes were still red. The moment she saw him, she hugged him. "Daddy, I didn't push that little brother."

Two days had passed, and Ling Dang was still dwelling on that incident.

Liang Xinhe looked at her eyes. "Baby, why are your eyes so red?"

"Daddy, last night we went to the hospital and saw that auntie." Ling Dang complained with grievance. "That auntie cursed at me. She called me a dog spawn..."

Liang Xinhe: "?!!"

"Auntie hit her." Ling Dang said. "And then she was taken away by the police uncles."

Though young in age, she was crystal clear when tattling. Ling Dang pressed her teary face against Liang Xinhe's shoulder with grievance. "Daddy, can we move out? Living with Da-bo is fine, living with Auntie is fine too, but I don't want to live with New Auntie and Grandma anymore. Grandma scolds Mommy."

Liang Xinhe said immediately, "Move. We'll move today."

Liang Shi stood behind Ling Dang and immediately said, "I didn't teach her to say that."

Liang Xinhe said helplessly, "No one said you did."

If he had been somewhat hesitant before, Liang Xinhe was now firmly resolved. There was still a huge pile of documents on his desk, but he couldn't care about any of that now. He told Liang Shi to call their older brother and ask what to do about the company. Should he come back to talk to Dad, or could he also just quit?

He really couldn't live like this for another day.

Liang Xinhe complained tearfully to Liang Xinzhou. He was working himself to death outside, only for Mom to bully his wife and child at home.

Liang Xinzhou asked him coldly, "So do you still think I was worrying too much back then?"

"No." Liang Xinhe immediately started flattering. "Ge, you're brilliant and mighty. I really... Are you living at Hualuwan now? Or Chenjiang? We might as well move near your place."

Liang Xinzhou: "....."

"Liang Shi is at Chenjiang. I'm at Hualuwan." Liang Xinzhou said. "You'd better stay away from us."

Liang Xinhe: "No way. When Dad comes looking for someone to settle accounts, you need to be in the front line."

Liang Xinzhou threatened, "Then I'll have to beat you up first."

Liang Xinhe: "...That's fine too."

Liang Xinhe was clinging to Liang Xinzhou no matter what. In his heart, his older brother was omnipotent.

Liang Xinzhou didn't say anything more after that. He just told him to move quickly if he was going to move. There was no need to make a scene face-to-face—just move out directly. Anyway, there wasn't much stuff, and they could buy new things.

The best decision Liang Xinhe had ever made was buying property when his older brother bought property. He just didn't buy as many as his older brother—only one unit at Hualuwan, bought in the building next to his brother's.

Liang Xinhe was a man of action. He told Liang Shi to take Ling Dang to his brother's place, then go home to pack up and move first.

Liang Shi told him about Ling Dang being falsely accused. Liang Xinhe promised Ling Dang, "Don't worry. Daddy will definitely get to the truth. I absolutely won't let my precious daughter be wronged."

And so, a dramatic "pulling the firewood from under the cauldron"² began.

Liang Shi took Ling Dang to Hualuwan to find Liang Xinzhou. The moment they entered, Liang Xinzhou also noticed Ling Dang's eyes.

Liang Shi said from the side, "She's been crying for two days."

Liang Xinzhou's face darkened immediately. He asked Ling Dang, "Who bullied you?"

Ling Dang was usually a little afraid of her Da-bo, but she hadn't seen him in a long time. Plus, compared to her New Auntie, she now felt Da-bo wasn't scary at all—he was very reliable.

So she nestled in her Da-bo's arms and tattled in fragments.

Although her words weren't entirely clear, the meaning she expressed was very clear.

After Liang Xinzhou finished listening, he directly pulled Ling Dang toward the door. "Which supermarket did you go to that day?"

Ling Dang answered, "The big supermarket right by our house."

Liang Shi hadn't even processed what was happening. Mainly, she hadn't expected Liang Xinzhou to make a decision so quickly. They hadn't even been inside for three minutes.

While she was still dazed, Liang Xinzhou stood at the door and called out, "Liang Shi, are you coming or not?"

Liang Shi: "....."

Almost without hesitation, Liang Shi responded, "Let's go!"

Footnotes:

¹ "Steal someone's wall" (撬牆角, qiào qiángjiǎo): A Chinese expression meaning to steal someone's romantic partner or to poach someone from a relationship. The imagery is of prying away at the corner of a wall until it crumbles.

² "Pulling the firewood from under the cauldron" (釜底抽薪, fǔ dǐ chōu xīn): A Chinese idiom meaning to remove the root cause of a problem, or to take drastic measures that undermine the foundation of something. Here it refers to the family dramatically moving out and potentially abandoning their roles in the family business, effectively removing themselves from the family power structure.

Chapter 99-7

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On the way to the supermarket, Liang Shi and Liang Xinzhou received a call from Rainbow.

Rainbow said, "Liang-jiejie, Teacher Qi asked me to give you something, but I forgot and put it back in my school bag. Can you come pick it up today?"

"Sure, can I come get it tonight?" As Liang Shi was speaking, she realized they would pass by Rainbow's neighborhood on the way to the supermarket. She changed her mind. "Are you home right now?"

"Yes, Mom and I are home." Rainbow answered.

Liang Shi said, "Then I'll come over now. Can you bring the stuff down to the entrance of your community?"

"Okay."

Liang Shi then had Liang Xinzhou drive to Rainbow's community first. When they went to pick up Rainbow, Ling Dang called out to her, "Rainbow, are you coming?"

Rainbow looked confused and asked, "Going where?"

"To get revenge for me!" Ling Dang clenched her little fists. "My Da-bo is taking us to beat up the bad guys!"

Rainbow hesitated for two seconds. "Let's go!"

Meanwhile, Liang Shi, sitting in the car, opened the letter that Gu Xingyue had passed along through Rainbow. Inside the envelope were several sheets of paper. The content on each page was very strange.

They were all symbols made of dots and dashes, filling several pages.

Liang Shi couldn't understand it. Rainbow leaned over to look, and Liang Shi asked her instead, "What is this? Can you understand it?"

Rainbow frowned and paused before saying, "It looks like Morse code."

Liang Shi handed her the papers. "Can you translate it?"

Rainbow fell into thought. Her fingers tapped on her leg following along with the symbols. Then she read out the first line: "February 13th, cloudy. I keep dreaming about that little sister lately. I don't know if she's grown up safely, but I really can't hold on anymore. Will death really make this world a better place?"